

The Picnic

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Synopsis: After his girlfriend's disappearance in a forest where dream, memory and reality are intertwined, a man tries to reconnect with her by returning to the area and hopefully vanquishing his demons.

Characters:

- Dan
- Anna
- Jennifer
- George
- The Prostitute
- Fred

Plot:

Prologue

With blood all over his face, Dan runs frantically through the forest. He stops, removes an apple from his pocket and bites it. He then rejoins Anna at their picnic. All the blood is suddenly gone and Dan recounts a strange dream he just had of someone drilling a hole into his nose.

Main Plot

At the picnic near an apple tree, Anna apologizes to Dan for their fight the night before and promises she has always been faithful throughout their relationship. Dan seems to believe her and they briefly reconcile. Through their interactions, it's clear Dan has an inferiority complex and Anna is his emotional cathexis, which Anna doesn't want to be since to her, it feels burdensome. They are suddenly interrupted by howls coming from distant wolves. Scared, they dash away through the forest, which becomes darker and darker as they venture deeper within the shadows of the trees. And when Dan looks back, **Anna has vanished.**

Three months later, there are still no signs of Anna. Dan's father, George, comes into his son's apartment to bring some comfort, as he usually does weekly since Anna's disappearance. Dan is now reclusive and unwilling to get out of the apartment, still deeply grieving the loss of his girlfriend. He talks about his love for Anna and how everything was going well in their relationship, until that fateful picnic. George seems to be puzzled by this and refers to what Dan had previously told him about Anna's infidelity. Dan doesn't recollect this conversation and becomes irked by his father's presence when he insists that Dan once truly believed Anna was unfaithful.

Dan then berates his father for being uncaring and absent to his mother, Jennifer. For Dan, this is the reason Jennifer is allegedly adulterous. George is shocked to hear all this and denies Jennifer's infidelity, claiming they always remained loyal to each other. He knows Dan has been distant towards his mother after he began dating

Anna, and practically cut her off after his girlfriend's disappearance. Hence, he insists that Dan visits his mother in the forthcoming days.

The next day, Dan returns to the forest in search of any traces of Anna. Since her disappearance, this is the first time he has been able to muster the courage to revisit this traumatic place, a considerable source of pain and despair for him. He goes to the apple tree and when he takes a bite from one apple, he immediately falls unconscious and finds himself transported to the day of his last picnic with Anna. However this time, their conversation plays out differently. Anna tries to gaslight Dan by accusing him of adultery and being neglectful. The scene mirrors the fight they had the night before the fateful picnic whereby the **exact same argument** occurred in Dan's apartment. The words exchanged and the tone of their voice are almost identical to that fight; only the location is different.

Dan returns to the present and is confused by his experience. He takes another bite from the same apple but nothing happens. On picking another apple from the tree and eating it, he is sent back to the picnic where, again, his conversation with Anna plays out differently. This time, Anna reprimands Dan for refusing to have sex with her, calling the lack of intimacy detrimental to their relationship. Dan tries to rationalize this by explaining his Madonna-whore complex whereby he confesses to really admiring Anna and being unable to "disrespect" her with carnal desire. He relates to Schopenhauer's views that sexual desire is one of the main causes of human misery since it can lead to jealousy and only serves as temporary relief. As per Sartre's views, Dan refuses to dehumanize Anna as an object of his desires, believing it would make their relationship less authentic and purely driven by sexual desire. Anna seems quite confused by this, saying Dan was never opposed to engaging in sexual activities when they first started dating. She angrily says Dan is trying to mask his loss of attraction for her through blatant intellectualization. This argument is identical to **another scene** taking place a few months ago at a hotel room where Dan refuses to have sex but Anna, frustrated and upset, forcefully goes down on him despite his objections.

Back to present, Dan regains consciousness and becomes overwhelmed by these events. He tries to phone his mother but she fails to respond. He then phones George and relates his strange discovery whereby each new apple he eats from that tree seems to awaken memories he has apparently forgotten and forces him to relive them. George, preoccupied by unknown matters, ignores Dan's words. With a dark and menacing voice, he accuses Dan of having done something irrevocable the night before. Dan doesn't know what he's talking about but George sternly affirms he is going to severely punish him, just like he used to do when Dan was a child but this time, he promises to give him his worst punishment yet. Perplexed and horrified, Dan hangs up.

Dan eats another apple and after being sent back to the picnic, he now becomes determined to alter the events presented to him. He tells a confused Anna that she's about to disappear. He takes her hand and runs away with her, making sure she's right by his side. But suddenly, they are surrounded by a pack of wolves. Almost immediately, Dan wakes up back in the present and vomits what he's just eaten. He theorizes that something out there must have prevented him from changing the past.

Whilst walking through the trees, he sees his father having sex with an unseen woman who he assumes is his mother, both completely naked and copulating on the grass. This reminds him of an episode from his past: an 11 years old Dan witnesses his parents having sex through a window back in his childhood house. In the forest, however, the woman's face is **blurred** and when George climaxes, the woman disappears. A swirling cloud surrounds George and once it dissipates, George has inexplicably metamorphosed into a doppelganger of Dan. The doppelganger cryptically explains to a mystified Dan that he represents the id, the repressed memories, and the latent content of his dreams.

The pack of wolves is seen overlooking them. Scared, Dan and the doppelganger walk away. The latter says that it is only through his help that Dan will vanquish the layers of psychological censorship covering the truth about Anna's disappearance and Dan's own psyche. He also claims that Dan has condensed all his troubles into that one picnic with Anna, which is why he keeps revisiting it. Being a proponent of free-will, Dan believes he can change the events he has been revisiting and even prevent them from happening because they feel like returning at a previous point in time. The doppelganger insists that this isn't time travel; these events have already happened and are just memories sometimes entwined with dreams and he can neither change nor escape them. He asks if Dan knows he is in a memory whilst reliving them. Dan ponders on his question and answers that he will use all his mental faculties to become aware of that and change the events in his memory as per his current self's will, regardless if it affects reality.

They both go to the mystical tree and eat an apple. Dan returns to the picnic but mere moments after his arrival, Anna transforms into another woman, a prostitute. The Prostitute leaves and Dan's doppelganger, also present, gestures at him from behind a tree to follow her. Dan seems to realize what is about to ensue and thinks he can alter that by abandoning The Prostitute. He thus bolts away in the opposite direction. Dan is reminded of one dreadful night: After his fight with Anna, Dan leaves the apartment. Whilst driving through the streets, he finds The Prostitute and they drive to an alley where Dan refuses any sexual activities and just wants to talk to her. There, after venting incessantly, Dan displaces his guilt over his crumbling relationship, along with all his frustrations, towards The Prostitute by strangling her to death.

Back in the forest, Dan stands terrorized on top of her dead body, having been unable to escape fate and the constraints of being in a memory. Dan's delusion intensifies and he refuses to believe these events are true and determined. The doppelganger believes Dan is repeating these past events in the forest as a form of repetition compulsion and tries to persuade him to accept reality as it truly is. Suddenly, a wolf attacks the doppelganger and brutally mauls him, degloving his face whilst he screams in extreme agony.

Dan manages to escape and eats another apple, after which he is sent back to the picnic. There, Anna is seemingly pregnant and about to give birth. Dan helps her deliver a strange bloody organic orb instead of a baby. Dan opens it and finds a letter marred with blood from a detective with photos of Anna copulating with another man. Again, the pack of wolves gaze at him. A similar scene happened before at Dan's apartment where he burns the images in denial. Anna arrives home shortly later and reveals that her pregnancy test came out

negative, after she has been experiencing false pregnancy symptoms. Despite receiving these images, he embraces Anna and reiterates his love for her, desperately clinging to the idea that she won't leave him.

Back to the forest, Dan finds Anna naked with Fred (the man in the pictures). He overhears them talking about him. She recounts her cognitive dissonance wherein she knows cheating goes against her values but she keeps doing it. She rationalizes it by blaming Dan for being neglectful. She laughs at how during her false pregnancy, Dan didn't even realize he couldn't have been the father since they didn't have sex during the timeframe she would have been impregnated. She suspects Dan has always known about her unfaithfulness but has denied it even to himself, repressed his doubts and ultimately, through reaction formation, became even more romantically attached to Anna. She is annoyed by Dan's affections and clinginess but refuses to leave him out of guilt. She also knows that deep inside, she feels validated and empowered by his unrequited love for her.

She mocks Dan's attempts to intellectualize all his problems to avoid emotionally dealing with them. But she admits she has been doing that too lately. She shares Schopenhauer's views that love is the source of endless striving and unfulfillment, as it is driven by the insatiable nature of human desires. True happiness can only be attained by transcending these desires and attachments, rather than indulging in them, something which Anna cannot do which consequently leads her to infidelity. She mentions Sartre's views of authenticity and freedom as to why she's unfaithful, namely to counter "bad faith" and stay true to her desires. She believes that the will-to-life concept, which posits that sexual desire is a powerful force driving individuals to procreate, leads to a cycle of suffering made up of jealousy, conflict and unfulfilled desires. Fred laughs at her ramblings and she laughs too, fully aware that she is unabashedly trying to justify her immorality by philosophizing pointlessly.

All of a sudden, Fred hears a noise. He turns his gaze and describes Dan hiding behind some bushes. He picks up a drilling machine, which has seemingly materialized from nowhere, and chases him. Dan runs away but falls and hits his head, falling unconscious. Dan then wakes up next to his mother, Jennifer (revealed to be an aged doppelganger of Anna), tending to his injuries by the riverside. Dan apologizes for being distant after starting his relationship with Anna but blames Jennifer for being cold and overprotective as to why he behaved like this. He says that he just wanted to supersede her lack of affection with Anna's.

He blames Jennifer for never returning the love he had for her and for always providing more attention to his father when he was a child. He also projects his frustrations on Jennifer and blames her for cheating on George, something he has no proof she did. He used to view his mother as an idealized version of himself and interprets her potential infidelity as a flaw within himself. Offended, Jennifer leaves without uttering a single word.

Out of the blue, George jumps out of a dense thicket, with a drilling machine in his hand, screaming that he will punish Dan for something he did. He pins him down but Dan strikes George with a rock and runs away. He then encounters his doppelganger again, who has been severely mutilated. Dan cries out how he wanted to ignore and forget everything he has been revisiting so far in the forest. The doppelganger reveals that after being attacked, he is now dead, and his presence here is merely a brief ghostly apparition. He says the surviving Dan will soon automatically assume his identity as the unconscious impulses/desires and the repressed side of himself. The doppelganger then urges Dan to eat two other apples and find the truth about what happened to

Jennifer and Anna respectively. Dan, puzzled, claims nothing happened to his mother and choosing ignorance over truth, he goes to the apple tree and burns it down with his lighter.

However one single apple survived the fire, having fallen from the tree. Dan reluctantly picks it up and battles himself over whether to eat it or not. He chooses to keep it in his pocket but is again attacked by George, who proceeds to drill a hole into Dan's nose. As blood gushes from the wound, a stream of blood also seems to be simultaneously exuding from his genitals. George then dashes away, his punishment completed, and Dan bolts in the opposite direction.

After some time, he stops, removes the apple from his pocket and bites it. He then rejoins Anna at their picnic. All the blood is suddenly gone and Dan recounts his recent encounter with his father as a dream he had of someone drilling a hole into his nose. Anna then transforms into Jennifer, much to Dan's bewilderment. Jennifer asks if he was happy with his relationship with Anna. After lengthily pondering on how to answer her question, Dan finally caves in and expresses his true feelings:

He strongly resents Anna and interprets her disappearance as wish-fulfillment. He now realizes that deep inside, he was elated by Anna's disappearance and the possibility that she's dead. He wanted her to suffer for all the internal turmoil she's made him endure through cheating, deception and gaslighting. Suddenly, Dan's and Jennifer's eyes meet and in the silence, he becomes terrorized when he remembers what is about to unfold. Like all the picnic encounters, he becomes aware that he is currently relieving a **memory**. He knows something truly horrific will happen, so he promptly leaves and begs Jennifer not to follow him.

In the original memory, Dan is in his parents' house, which Dan visited the night before coming to the forest to search for Anna, three months after her disappearance. At last, he listened to his father's pleas to come visit his mother. In his conversation with Jennifer, he says that he relates to Nietzsche's views that his love for Anna was in fact an unconscious desire to possess and control her. When he failed to do so, he repressed all his impulses and jealousy deep inside his unconscious. He became more submissive and turned a blind eye to her infidelity. This cathartic moment is countered by a surge of guilt and self-loathing, wherein he blames himself for Anna's infidelity. He also condemns Jennifer's treatment of him when he was a child as the catalyst to his persistent loneliness and overcompensating clinginess. He experiences a moment of psychosis and sees Jennifer as Anna. Burning with rage, he smacks his own mother to the floor and climbs on top of her. Without hesitation, he removes her underwear and rapes her. Her screams mean nothing to him and when he breaks free from his psychosis and realizes what he is doing, he **does not** stop. His rage turns to pleasure and his sickening elation destroys Jennifer's sanity. Through his moans, he admits that it's only now that he feels like his mother really loves him, before finally climaxing inside her.

Back at the forest, Jennifer cries in pain and revulsion at what her son has just done to her. Dan is right next to her, despite having seemingly walked away earlier. He says he no longer cares about what really happened to Anna and mutters to himself that everything that transpired inside the forest is not reality, blatantly ignoring the events' connection to his memories and reality. He then mentions that before suppressing all those harmful

memories for good, he still has one thing left to do. As Jennifer falls into a catatonic state, Dan walks away, indifferent and detached.

Sometimes later, he stands over the agonizing George in his parents' house, with a drilling machine in his hand, having just drilled a hole into his father's nose.

Epilogue

At the forest, a pack of wolves devours what seems to be human meat before howling into the distance.

The End